

The Touch

Prologue

Gray Stone & Heartache

Who doesn't dread a funeral? Especially if the person being buried was the one you were going to spend the rest of your time on Earth with. To grow old with. Have children with. How do you recover from that? How do you replace someone irreplaceable?

This isn't football. This is life, not a game. There are no substitutions. There is only starting over again. But can it be done? Starting over? If you learn to let go, maybe. People do it all the time. If they somehow find the inner strength to move on with their lives then maybe. If they allow their hearts to love again no matter how guilty it makes them feel to move on, maybe. Yeah, maybe.

A lone figure stood sadly over a grave, his face partially hidden by the umbrella he was holding, which failed to keep him completely dry. Light rain, like crystal droplets, bounced off his broad shoulders, covered by the London Fog trench coat that he wore. The young man glanced up from the headstone and gazed at the meticulously manicured lawns, and the variety of flower arrangements loved ones had placed at the foot of innumerable graves of the people who had been special in their lives. People who had shared their lives with them. People who were no longer part of this world.

He stifled a deep-seated, agonizing sob. His piercing dark eyes continued to scan the premises; eyes devoid of hope, joy and a future he had planned to experience with her. He disliked being there. Who wouldn't? Cemeteries were so final, so ending. They were the somber monuments to life's finale.

His eyes returned to the grave. The disbelief of seeing her name written across the headstone had not yet left him, despite the fact that she had passed a full year before. That's why, for the countless time, he read the inscription permanently embedded across the beautifully crafted stone: *Sara, a storm was always brewing in your eyes*. He could not believe her body was there. He did not want to believe that her body was there, even though he was staring at the truth.

He could hardly speak. Raw, unbearable emotion flooded his pleasant, captivating voice. "I've cried. So much. That I'm numb inside. I feel guilty and unfaithful when I'm with anyone else. I have to go on. I know that. But I don't know how. I don't know how, Sara. I miss you. I miss you so much."

He kissed his fingertips then lovingly placed them on the coldness of the gravestone. Allowing himself another moment to grieve, he turned and walked away. He could barely do that. He stopped in the middle of the cemetery to try and curb the tears flooding his eyes. There had been so many shed. There would be so many more. And he knew it.

As if to emphasize the gloom piercing the very core of him,

rain began to pour heavily from the dark clouds in the sky. Dark clouds which mirrored the ones encircling his heart. He gathered the strength to walk on. To walk away. And as he did, lightning flashed, thunder roared. Ray Griffin dreaded what he had to look forward to. It was life without Sara.

Chapter One

Beth

This was one of the worst storms to hit the Bay Area in quite a while, but rain and thunder weren't on the mind of Beth Talbot, a dark-haired beauty a few years out of law school. She had something else on her mind, and not much different from any other young girl who sat in a movie theater staring at the big screen, sighing at the romantic story unfolding before her eyes. For Beth, like many young girls, or women of any age for that matter, it was a story, which somehow in real life, almost never ended like they thought it should. Or like they wished it would. And so, a girl's dreams and her imaginings were often shattered when Mr. Right never showed up. For this reason, more times than not, she would reluctantly settle for Mr. Almost Right.

After one or two failed encounters of the heart, it doesn't take long for a woman to find out, especially in today's dating world of musical chairs, that life isn't a Hollywood movie. That knights in shining armor are fictitious characters only found in dreamy novels. But then again, Beth was a romantic. She believed that, somewhere out there, her knight in shining armor was atop a galloping steed, bravely taking on peril after peril, in his search of her. Now why these fantasies concerning the future love of her life were all set in Medieval Times, was a source of puzzling amusement to Beth. Perhaps, just maybe, she should have

spent more time concentrating on keeping the metallic steed she was driving from weaving in and out of the traffic lane she was supposed to be in.

HOOOOONK!!!!

Her BMW nearly collided with a delivery truck swerving to miss her. She turned her steering wheel sharply, away from the truck, causing her Beamer to hydroplane. "Oh God!" She felt the helplessness of gliding on a slippery sheet of water as her car fishtailed. "Oh, God, oh, God, oh, God!" Unfortunately for Beth, God wasn't driving. But apparently He heard her screaming. Beth managed to navigate her car, more like wildly slide, back into her traffic lane.

Calming down, she turned to the burly driver and shouted at her passenger-side window, her lips over pronouncing on purpose. "I am so sorry!"

Not even Superman, himself, could have heard her over the rain pelting their respective windows, which sounded a lot like popcorn popping, only much, much louder. Not to mention that the burly driver may have had a better chance of hearing Beth if her window had been open. In spite of rain dropping in bucket loads, the driver rolled his window down at the next intersection where the traffic light had turned red.

Beth lowered her passenger-side window just in time for her to hear him shout "Fuck you! And fuck your fuckin' car! You dumb Beamer driving bitch!"

"That was rude!"

He didn't hear Beth. The truck was already making a right turn and disappearing into the early evening darkness. Winter was here. The days were short, as well as chilly. After all, it was San Francisco. It got cold up north. She shut her passenger side window, and attempted to wipe off some of the rain which soaked the inside of her car. While she was doing that the light turned green. A nanosecond later, if not sooner, car horns began to rudely blare for her to move it.

HONK!

She glared into the rearview and yelled at the long line of impatient commuters inside their respective vehicles, as if they could actually hear her, let alone see her. "The friggin' light barely turned green you booger eating morons!"

HONK! HONK! HOOOOOOOONK!!!!

"For crying out loud!" As she drove away, windshield wipers working overtime, Beth decided it would probably be much safer to spend less time dreaming about her medieval knight, and more time concentrating on her driving. "Good idea."

Nevertheless, as she attempted to do just that, concentrate on her driving, an even bigger truck launched a mini-tidal wave which splashed over her car, flooding her windshield with a wall of water and blinding her vision. Not having learned her lesson, as her car glided on another slippery sheet of water, she yanked her steering wheel. Fishtailing, the Beamer veered into the next

traffic lane, nearly sideswiping the large truck.

"Oh, God, oh, God, oh, God!"

It must have been a slow day, because He came to her rescue once again. Beth managed to swerve, slide and skid back into her traffic lane. Regaining some semblance of composure, she wanted to apologize to the driver. But she remembered how well that was received only moments before. She decided it would be better to drive on without apologizing. That was when she heard the truck she nearly hit, honking. Beth turned in time to see the trucker flip her off and roar away.

"Thanks for showing me your IQ. You big jerk."

In her defense, no lawyer pun intended, it was raining cats and dogs; not literally. But the streets were literally flooded. Tense, and squeezing the wheel from the stress of driving in the pounding rain, Beth turned the radio on. She was too nervous to reach into her purse and take out her iPod. She didn't want to take her eyes off the road.

"That's all I need. Another demonstration of my expert slip and slide driving technique."

As one tune faded another came on. The radio personality on-the-air spoke over the intro of the song. "Weather like this makes me think somewhere nearby an old, drunk Indian is dancing up a storm." He was referring to the Native American rain dance. A noticeable smile appeared on Beth's face. She glanced at the radio while he continued with "Here's U2 on Bay 93."

The BMW kicked up waves of water along with the rest of the traffic on California Street. The rainfall was so heavy that it looked like a giant water fight between cars and trucks heading to wherever. It was a bad storm even by San Francisco standards. The BMW, dripping wet, rolled into an underground parking garage nestled below a skyscraper. Beth pulled into an empty spot and turned the wipers off.

She breathed a sigh of relief. "Whew! I made it. Driving in this storm SUCKS!"

She turned off the engine, but left the radio on, which was unusual for her; the fact that Beth had it on at all. She rarely listened to radio. Like most people, her iPod supplied her music needs and with no commercial interruptions. Now that she had the time to safely do it, Beth could have taken her iPod out of her purse. But she decided not to. Beth needed and wanted to hear a real live human being talking to her. She didn't know why. She just did. And who could blame her?

Today's world was jam-packed with annoying, prerecorded messages with instructions on how to reach a department or, God help you, a particular individual. Usually, the experience had a successful conclusion. That is, if you were a patient person and the call hadn't dropped on you after being on hold forever. That would even piss off the Pope. And he is supposed to be a pretty chill dude. Let's face it. Anyone who wears a pointy hat like he does has got to be.

For whatever reason, Beth sat with the radio on even though she was there to meet friends, and was running late. That didn't matter. She needed time to recover from the commuter fiasco that she somehow was able to escape, unscathed. So rather than hurry, Beth gazed out her window, which displayed a string of raindrops sliding downward in crisscrossing patterns creating a network of transparent trails.

A radio spot was playing. She was not paying any attention to it. Who listens to commercials anyway? On the other hand, if one of her favorite songs had been playing, she would not have heard it either. Her mind was elsewhere. Very elsewhere. It was in a daydream, in a far distant land with her knight in shining armor. The dreaminess in her eyes slowly faded, and her romantic fantasy soon turned depressing for Beth.

So what was up with that? She was a successful rising star in the law firm she worked for. She had a razor sharp mind for investing, which helped her bank account grow considerably and steadily. She had friends, a family. Beth's life was exciting. Still, she wasn't happy. She just wasn't. An important cog was missing. Beth was alone, and lonely.

Sure she had wonderful friends, and a great family, and a blossoming career, all of that. She was intelligent, articulate and all of her fingers and toes were intact. She didn't need a man to support her. She'd never fall into the trap which tends to snare most women. She would never marry a man for financial

security. Besides, Beth didn't have to. She didn't need a man for that. But even if she didn't need a man in her life, she so wanted a man; that special man. The One. And that is why Beth would never settle. He had to be The One.

"Where is he?"

Beth stared out the window as if waiting for her knight in shining armor to gallop up in his white charger, and carry her off to Happy Ever After. Of course, Beth was no idiot. She was well aware that Happy Ever After was filled with obstacles and many bumps in the road. And that is why, he had to be The One. Because if he was, they would handle those obstacles and bumps in the road together, as one. She would be there for him and he would be there for her. There would be no reason to hear I need my space, or worse, experience a bitter divorce.

But he was nowhere to be seen. Her knight in shining armor. He was nowhere to be found. Would he ever find her? Would Beth ever find him? What if they never found each other? What if they failed to spot one another? To notice one another in passing? And then, like it always did, the worst scenario played out in Beth's beleaguered mind. What if she, in the end, settled? What if her knight settled? What if they never, ever got the chance to meet, to be together? Beth shook her head, because it didn't matter.

"I will never, ever settle. I would rather live alone. And lonely. Than do that."

She continued to stare out the window. Her eyes glazed over while those gloomy thoughts riddled her brain. The same thoughts which always managed to attack her mind and heart when Beth was most vulnerable. Lately, however, Beth's thoughts were invading her inner self with much more intensity and precision, like a surgical military strike. And tonight, they had gotten worse. Beth dwelled on the times when she mistakenly believed she had found him, The One.

It always began the same way. Happiness and giddiness at the start of the relationship. It was so magical, she struggled getting to sleep at night. Her thoughts filled with engagement rings, weddings and a future with the love of her life. But it would end like it always did, her emotions exploding in pieces. The pure disappointment of being wrong again about someone who she thought could be The One was painfully devastating. In other words, it hurt like hell. Thing is, Beth didn't care if they got married or not, as long as he was The One. And that hand-in-hand they would be together for life.

She snapped out of her funk when an annoying commercial for an over-priced cable company, which of them wasn't and for what, finished, and the radio personality came back on. "It's time for me to whip out my Peter..." His long pause made her stare at her radio in minor shock. "Frampton song of the night...Baby I Love Your Way, on Bay 93." The tune started to play.

She giggled. "Weirdo!" Her giggles became laughter. It made

her feel a little better. Beth reached into her purse and took out some tissues, and wiped the tears she had not noticed until now. Her deep dark eyes looked into the rearview mirror to make sure her makeup was still on. It was. Her beautiful face smiled back at her.

“Why do girls cry to feel better?” She sadly shook her head at the rhetorical question. Beth got out of her car and hurried toward the building elevators.